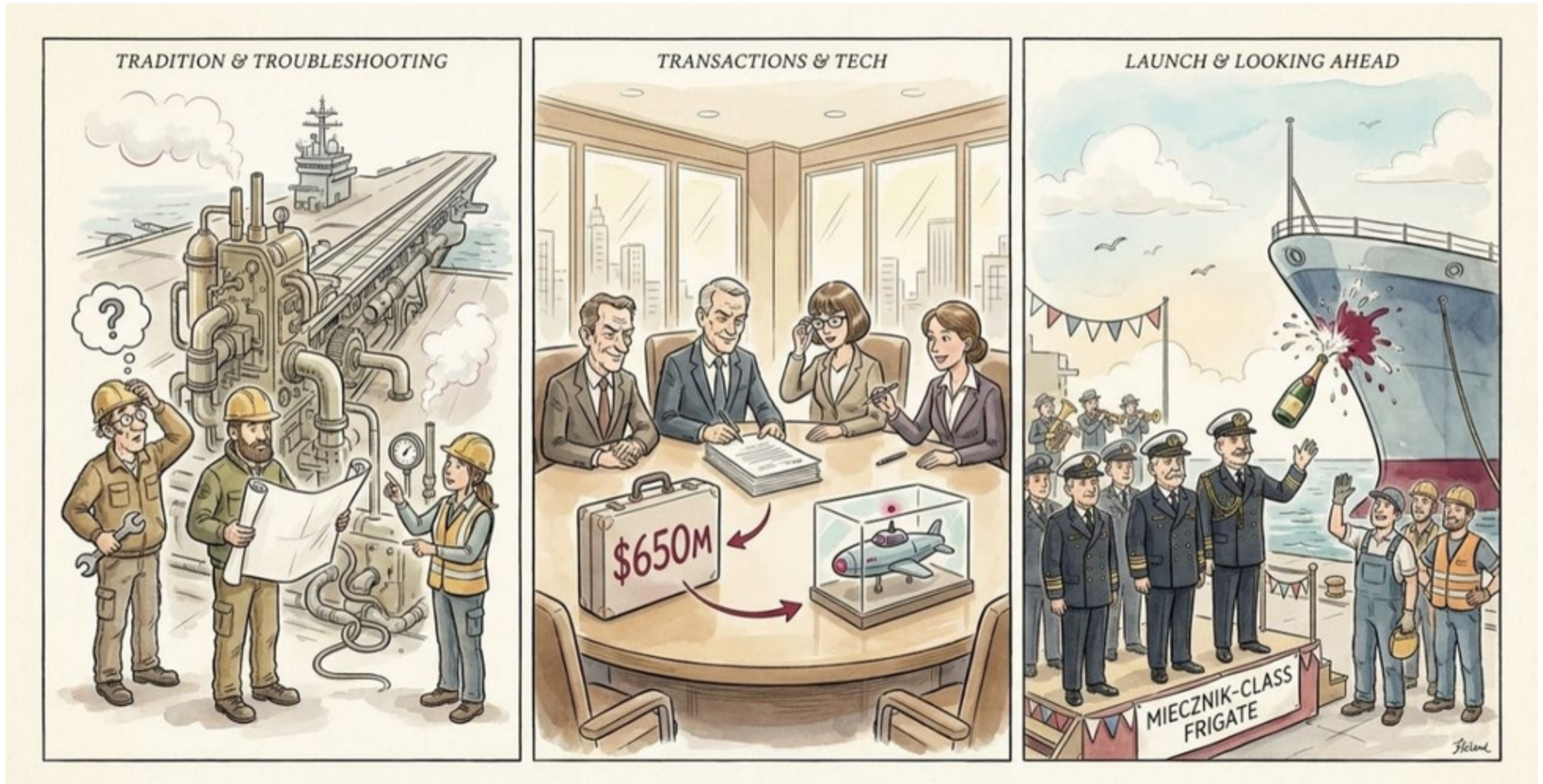


Defense Brief

August 14, 2026



Trump Orders Steam Catapults Back on Ford-Class Carriers and a Fifth Public Shipyard; AEVEX Buys BlackSea for \$650M

The Bottom Line

The signature development of the day is a US naval-industrial reversal: Trump ordered future Ford-class carriers back to steam catapults and hydraulics and directed a fifth public shipyard for submarine repair, overruling General Atomics' warning about sunk costs — a decision that will ripple through carrier design, supplier base and readiness for years. Around it, the defense market stayed busy: AEVEX is consolidating unmanned maritime capability with a \$650M BlackSea acquisition, Poland floated the first Miecznik frigate to rebuild its Baltic fleet, C4ADS quantified a 75-flight Russian air bridge into the Sahel, and both Boeing and DARPA pushed affordability-first approaches to seekers and hypersonic strike. The through-line across the day is cost and industrial capacity: Western navies and missile programs are all trying to solve the same problem of producing and sustaining more capability at scale, even as strategic posture shifts in the Baltic, the Sahel and the Indo-Pacific.